▶ PUNJAB

THE DUNKI REPUBLIC



Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

Rivers flowing down from the Himalayan massifs are known to have fickle habits—they curl about, meander and, if they stray far enough, get captured by bigger river systems. It's natural that politics in Punjab, a province named for five rivers, is influenced by that naughty ecological habit. Its glib practitioners breach party embankments at the speed of thought. The state is headed for its first-ever four-cornered electoral contest, and a wise punter will hold his hand. The only thing you want to bet on is that every party is made up of other parties. The BJP has fielded six candidates for the state's 13 seats so far—four are 'dunkis'. AAP has announced nine candidates—again, four dunkis. The chief prey base for both is the hapless Congress. The BJP is generous enough to accommodate more eclectic resumes, of course. Take Sushil Rinku. First he freelanced for the Congress, becoming the Jalandhar West MLA in 2017. He decamped to AAP just in time for the 2023 bypoll to the Jalandhar LS seat, and delivered it to the 'party with a difference'. Now, he's the BJP candidate. The saffron commissars have also plucked Congress's sitting MP from Ludhiana, Ravneet Bittu. As for its Patiala MP Preneet Kaur, she already had a spouse visa via Amarinder Singh. Popstar Hans Raj Hans, shifted out from North West Delhi to Faridkot, is a BJP veteran by those standards—having joined in 2019, after peregrinating through the Akali Dal and Congress. AAP boasts a saffron defector in

▶ TAMIL NADU

Dravidian Jathedars

The farmers' agitation had a strong Punjabi accent and its seeds of dissent have flown far in India's political winds. The five-year-old Bahujan Dravida Party (BDA) has fielded seven candidates who could be emblems of national cross-cultivation—they are all Tamils who embraced Sikhism after taking part in the 2021 protests. "Our aim is to bring social change at the grassroots by establishing a cultural identity through Sikhism," claims BDA founder Jeevan Singh, a Tamil from Thoothukudi. A Buddhist with the BSP earlier, his goals haven't changed. "Our party works to empower the SCs, STs, OBCs and religious minorities who form 95 per cent of Indians," he says. The BDA is in the fray in southern Tamil Nadu, and Jeevan hopes the neo-Sikhs will add a vibrant new colour to the Periyarist rainbow. ■

